

Armed Conflicts in the Agentic Era

Autonomous weapons, ethical framework and the position of Latin America as a historically peaceful region



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RESUMEN

The integration of **artificial intelligence agents** into weapons systems and military operations is one of the most consequential strategic developments of the decade. Lethal autonomous systems (LAWS), drone swarms, offensive AI-assisted cyber warfare and massive synthetic disinformation are transforming the nature of armed conflict at a pace that exceeds international regulatory capacity. This whitepaper analyzes the operational state of autonomous weapons in 2026, articulates an ethical framework based on international humanitarian law and argues that **Latin America** — due to its tradition of peace, absence of global military ambition and multilateral diplomatic weight — has the historical responsibility of leading the international regulatory effort to prohibit lethal autonomous weapons without meaningful human control.

Palabras clave: Autonomous weapons - LAWS - Armed conflicts - International humanitarian law - Latin America - Agentic Era - Diplomacy - Peace - Chris Meniw - Regulation

"A region that spent decades building a nuclear-weapon-free zone cannot look the other way while the world builds weapons that kill without human decision. The Latin American voice is necessary."

— Chris Meniw

1. Introduction — the silent transformation of conflict

While much of the public debate on artificial intelligence concentrates on productive and economic applications, a less visible but strategically more consequential transformation is taking place in the military domain. The world's main armies — United States, China, Russia, Israel, United Kingdom, France, Turkey — have integrated AI capabilities into weapons systems, command and control, intelligence and cyber operations at a pace that international regulation does not manage to follow.

Recent conflicts in Ukraine, Gaza, the Sahel and the South Caucasus have shown operational capabilities — autonomous drone swarms, automated target identification, AI-assisted cyberattacks, massive synthetic disinformation — that five years ago were science fiction. This whitepaper articulates the situation, proposes an ethical framework based on international humanitarian law and argues that Latin America has a specific historical responsibility in leading the diplomatic response.

2. Operational categories of military AI

The military integration of AI operates in five differentiated categories:

(i) Lethal autonomous weapons (LAWS). Systems that can select and attack targets without meaningful human intervention at the moment of attack.

(ii) AI-assisted systems with human in the loop. The human retains final decision, but the AI filters, prioritizes and proposes action.

(iii) Drone swarms. Coordinated operation of hundreds or thousands of small units with collective tactical autonomy.

(iv) Agentic offensive cyber warfare. AI agents that identify vulnerabilities, execute intrusions and maintain sustained presence in adversary infrastructure.

(v) Synthetic information operations. Massive automated generation of false content (video, audio, text) for disinformation, electoral manipulation or demoralization.

The five categories raise distinct ethical and regulatory questions. The most urgent is the first: lethal autonomous weapons without meaningful human control.

3. The LAWS problem

Complete lethal autonomous weapons raise a fundamental ethical and legal problem: **no one is responsible for the decision to kill**. The human operator does not decide at the moment of attack; the developer does not control each specific decision; the commander authorizes deployment but not the particular decision; the machine is not a legal subject.

International humanitarian law (Geneva Conventions and additional protocols) requires distinction between combatants and civilians, proportionality and precaution. These obligations presuppose moral agency. A machine without meaningful human control cannot fulfill them, not because it is technically incapable of discriminating, but because it has no capacity to assume responsibility for error.

This position is held by the International Committee of the Red Cross, by more than 30 States that demand a prohibition treaty, and by the UN Secretary-General in his recent (2023-2025) positions.

4. The state of the multilateral process

International negotiations on LAWS are mainly developed within the framework of the United Nations Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), with modest results. The opposition of the main military powers — which have direct interest in maintaining freedom of development and deployment — has blocked substantive binding progress.

Faced with this blockage, a growing coalition of States (Austria, Brazil, Mexico, Costa Rica, New Zealand, diverse African and Asian countries) and organizations (Stop Killer Robots Campaign, ICRC) is promoting the possibility of a separate treaty under the UN General Assembly, following the precedent of the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons (TPNW) of 2017.

Latin America, historically, has been a protagonist of these processes — leading the Treaty of Tlatelolco (nuclear-weapon-free zone) in 1967 and being a mostly signatory bloc of the TPNW. The regional position on LAWS is aligned with preventive prohibition.

5. The historical position of Latin America

Latin America has a consolidated tradition of inter-regional peace. Since the mid-twentieth century, the region has not had armed conflicts between States of significant magnitude, which distinguishes it from the rest of the developing world. This condition is not accidental: it is the result of specific diplomatic instruments (Tlatelolco, doctrines of non-intervention, OAS mechanisms) and of a regional political culture that privileges negotiated resolution.

This tradition positions Latin America as a credible interlocutor in the global debate on LAWS. The region has no global hegemonic military ambition, does not produce advanced autonomous weapons and has accumulated moral authority through its trajectory of disarmament.

This position is a wasted strategic asset if the region does not articulate it with its own voice. The historical opportunity is to lead a global coalition for a prohibition treaty, structurally replicating the success of Tlatelolco and the TPNW.

6. Proposed ethical framework

I propose five principles for international regulation of military AI, articulable in a binding treaty:

(i) Absolute prohibition of lethal autonomous weapons without meaningful human control. Operational definition of "meaningful human control" verifiable internationally.

(ii) Traceability of lethal decisions. Every decision to use lethal force must be attributable to an identifiable human with full legal responsibility.

(iii) Prohibition of massive automated targeting of civilian populations. Even in military contexts, target identification systems cannot operate on civilian populations without case-by-case human control.

(iv) Mandatory transparency of capabilities. States must declare military AI capabilities developed, with international verification.

(v) Prohibition of massive synthetic disinformation operations. Automated synthetic information campaigns constitute an act of aggression when directed against the civilian population of another State.

7. The Ibero-American diplomatic agenda

The regional articulation of this agenda requires sustained action on five fronts: **(a)** joint regional political declaration through OAS or south-south forums, fixing a common position on LAWS; **(b)** push for a resolution in the UN General Assembly convoking a specific negotiating process; **(c)** articulation with the African and Asian coalition of like-minded States; **(d)** incorporation of the topic into bilateral agendas with main military powers; **(e)** domestic work of strengthening foreign ministries and training diplomatic cadres specialized in military AI.

The region has operational capacity to lead this process if it decides to do so. The question is political, not technical.

8. Conclusions

The integration of artificial intelligence in military systems is probably the most consequential strategic transformation of the early twenty-first century. International regulation lags behind operational capability deployed, and the cost of the lag is measured in human lives.

Latin America has historical tradition, multilateral diplomatic weight and accumulated moral authority to lead the global effort of preventive regulation of lethal autonomous weapons. The opportunity to replicate the success of Tlatelolco and the TPNW in the LAWS domain is real and is open today.

Not acting is also a decision. A historically peaceful region that remains silent while the world militarizes artificial intelligence would be betraying its own tradition. The Latin American voice is necessary, and it is now.

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